

FEMA to test soil at Eaton fire sites

The agency reverses its stance, plans to check lead levels at 100 burned homes.

By Tony Briscoe and Noah Haggerty

In a remarkable reversal, the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency is expected to announce that the Federal Emergency Management Agency will pay for soil testing for lead at 100 homes that were destroyed by the Eaton fire and cleaned up by federal disaster workers.

The forthcoming announcement would mark an about-face for FEMA officials, who repeatedly resisted calls to test properties for toxic substances after federal contractors finished removing fire debris. The new testing initiative follows reporting by The Times that workers repeatedly violated cleanup protocols, possibly leaving fire contaminants behind or moving them into unwanted areas, according to federal reports.

The EPA plan, presented to a small group of environmental experts and community members on Jan. 5, said the agency would randomly select 100 sites from the 5,600 homes that had burned down in the Eaton fire and where the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers oversaw the removal of ash, debris and a layer of soil. The soil samples would be collected near the surface and about 6 inches below ground.

Sampling is expected to begin next week, with test results published in April.

During the Jan. 5 presentation, some attendees questioned whether the testing would meaningfully assess whether properties are safe to rebuild on.

Local environmental health advocates worry the EPA testing is designed only to justify FEMA's decision not to undertake comprehensive soil testing, instead of providing real relief to their communities.

"The EPA's plan to run a study that retroactively validates a limited soil-removal response after the L.A. Fires is deeply concerning, especially when there is ample in-



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times



ALEJANDRA RAJAL For The Times

CROWDS in Los Angeles protest the U.S. removal of Venezuela's president, top; Venezuelan activist Andrea Paola Hernández fled the country, as did relatives.

Venezuelans across the globe ask: What's next?

Eight million people were forced into exile under Maduro's rule. They're unsure if it's safe to go home.

By Kate Linticum

MEXICO CITY — Andrea Paola Hernández has one sister in Ecuador and another in London. She has cousins in Colombia, Chile, Argentina and the United States.

All fled poverty and political repression in Venezuela. Hernández, a human rights activist and an outspoken critic of the country's authoritarian leader, Nicolás Maduro, eventually left too.

Since 2022 she has lived in Mexico City, working odd jobs for under-the-table pay because she lacks legal status. She cries most days and dreams of reuniting with her far-flung relatives and

friends. "We just want our lives back," she said.

One of Maduro's darkest legacies was the exodus of 8 million Venezuelans during his 13-year rule, one of the largest mass migrations in modern history. The flight of a third of the country's population ripped apart families and has shaped the cultural and political landscape in the dozens of nations where Venezuelans have settled.

The surprise U.S. operation to capture Maduro this month prompted mixed feelings among the diaspora. Relief, but also apprehension.

From Europe to Latin America to the U.S., those who left are asking whether

they finally can go home. And if they do, what would they return to?

'An ounce of justice'

Hernández was distressed by the U.S. attack, which killed dozens of people and is widely seen as illegal under international law. Still, she celebrated Maduro's arrest as "an ounce of justice after decades of injustice."

She is wary of what is to come.

President Trump repeatedly has touted Venezuela's vast oil reserves, saying little about restoring democracy to the country. He says the U.S. will work with Maduro's vice president, Delcy Rod

A defiant Fed chair stands up to White House

Powell says he won't back down on interest rates, accuses Trump of legal intimidation.

By Michael Wilner, Laurence Darmiento and Ana Ceballos

WASHINGTON — White House officials were caught by surprise when a post appeared Sunday night on the Federal Reserve's official social media channel, with Jerome H. Powell, its chairman, delivering a plain and clear message.

President Trump was again weaponizing the Justice Department to intimidate, Powell said to the camera, standing before an American flag. This time, he added, it wasn't going to work.

The lack of any warning for officials in the West Wing, confirmed to The Times, was yet another exertion of independence from a Fed chair whose stern resistance to presidential pressure has made him an outlier in Trump's Washington.

Powell was responding to grand jury subpoenas delivered to the Fed on Friday re-

lated to his congressional testimony over the summer regarding construction work at the Reserve.

"The threat of criminal charges is a consequence of the Federal Reserve setting interest rates based on our best assessment of what will serve the public, rather than following the preferences of the president," Powell said.

"This is about whether the Fed will be able to continue to set interest rates based on evidence and economic conditions," he added, "or whether instead monetary policy will be directed by political pressure or intimidation."

For months, Trump and his aides have harshly criticized Powell for his decision-making on interest rates, which the president believes should be dropped faster. On various occasions, Trump has threatened to fire Powell — a move that legal experts, and Powell himself, have said would be illegal — before pulling back.

The Trump administration is currently arguing before the Supreme Court that the president should have the ability to fire the heads of independent agencies at will, despite prior rulings [See Powell, A6]



JACQUELYN MARTIN Associated Press

JEROME H. POWELL'S post came after subpoenas related to a building project were delivered to the Fed.

Trump says Iran wants to negotiate

President's comments come as death toll in that country's protests climbs to at least 599.

By Jon Gambrell, Julia Nihonson and Amer Madhani

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Iran wants to negotiate with Washington after his threat to strike the Islamic Republic over its crackdown on protesters in nationwide demonstrations that activists said Monday had left at least 599 people dead.

Iran had no direct reaction to Trump's comments, which came after the foreign

minister of Oman — long an interlocutor between Washington and Tehran — traveled to Iran over the weekend. It also remains unclear just what Iran could promise, particularly as Trump has set strict demands over its nuclear program and its ballistic missile arsenal, which Tehran insists is crucial for its national defense.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, speaking to foreign diplomats in Tehran, insisted "the situation has come under total control" in remarks that blamed the U.S. and Israel for the violence, without offering evidence.

"That's why the demonstrations turned violent and bloody, to give an excuse to

[See Iran, A3]

The rise and fall of the Sprinkles empire

By Suhauna Hussain

After the dot-com bubble burst in the early 2000s, Candace Nelson reevaluated her career. She had just been laid off from a boutique investment banking firm in San Francisco's tech startup scene and realized she wanted a change.

From her home she launched a custom cake service that soon morphed into an idea for a cupcake-focused bakery. Nelson and her husband — whom she met at the Bay Area firm where she

had worked — then pooled their savings, moved to Southern California and together opened Sprinkles Cupcakes in a 600-square-foot Beverly Hills storefront.

The store quickly sold out on opening day in 2005, and over the next two decades the Sprinkles brand exploded across the country, opening dozens of locations of its specialty bakeries as well as mall kiosks and its signature around-the-clock cupcake ATMs in

several states.

But now the iconic cupcake brand is no more.

Sprinkles abruptly shut down all of its locations on Dec. 31, leaving hundreds of retail employees across California, Arizona, Florida, Nevada, Texas, Utah and Washington, D.C., in a lurch with little notice and no severance and scrambling to fulfill a surge of orders from customers clamoring to

[See Cupcakes, A10]

VR devices prepare inmates for life after prison

By Haven Daley and Christopher Weber

CHOWCHILLA, Calif. — Jacob Smith has been in prison for two decades, but he and other inmates are still taking regular trips to far-flung, exotic locales. No passport required, just a virtual reality headset.

"I went to Thailand, man!" Smith recalled with a grin, describing the first time he strapped on a VR device and was transported to the lush landscapes and bustling markets of Southeast Asia.

A Los Angeles County-based nonprofit is bringing



HAVEN DALEY Associated Press

THE PROJECT for Valley State Prison inmates aims "to blow their minds and also educate their minds."

the technology to California prisons with the goal of providing inmates a brief escape and, more important, exposure to real-world scenarios that will prepare them to reenter society.

During a weeklong program last month, incarcerated men at Valley State Prison in the Central Valley town of Chowchilla sat on metal folding chairs in a common area. They shuffled in their seats as they were outfitted with the headsets that resemble opaque goggles. Their necks contorted slightly and smiles spread across their faces as the high-definition videos

[See VR, A14]

Racy romances and self-care

A Monrovia book club founded by a therapist isn't afraid to dive into mental health issues. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Driver in custody after Iran protest

Man who steered his U-Haul truck into the crowd in Westwood is being held without bail, police say. CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather

Sunny and warm. L.A. Basin: 78/53. B6

Markets

..... A11

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ROBERT GAUTHIER L.A. Times
JUSTIN HERBERT is sacked on Sunday night.

Familiar ending for the Chargers

Herbert and the offense manage just a field goal against Patriots in third consecutive early playoff exit, 16-3. SPORTS, B10